

everything is to your liking. You know where to find me if you need me. I will let you get settled in and... sleep."

"No one is buying the friends act," Martin mindlinked me as we said goodbye to Mrs Andersen.

"Apparently not. We are lucky we didn't decide to pretend to be dating. They would have made tomorrow into a double wedding," I told him and I could see him snickering. We got ready for bed. Martin offered to sleep on the floor, which I refused. We were all adults and I trusted him. The bed was big enough for the two of us to sleep in without it being awkward. Before we went to bed, I called Finlay and Martin called Sam. Everything was going well at the meeting of the packs, according to Finlay. But I heard how tired he sounded and I knew something was up. But it wasn't the time to talk about it. If he told me everything was fine, whatever it was that bothered him didn't have an impact on the pack. So it could wait until we all were back home again.

The day of the wedding we had breakfast with the sisters. The ceremony would take place in the afternoon out on Jessie's farm and the reception was to take place in the barn.

"Who has heard of getting married outside? On a farm?" Mrs Andersen huffed. "It's only proper to have the ceremony in the church."

"Honestly Amanda, you sound like a bitter old prune. You need to get with the times. People are getting married in all kinds of exciting places nowadays. I read about a couple who did it in a hot-air balloon," Mrs Jones told her sister.

"Heathens the lot of them," Mrs Andersen said. Martin and I listened while the sisters continued their bickering.

"I wonder what she would think about our mating ceremonies," Martin mindlinked me. I almost choked on my coffee picturing Mrs Andersen in her Sunday best hiking out into the middle of the woods, listening to vows being said in honour of the moon and then watching how everyone shifted into wolves. I tried hard not to laugh and gave him an accusing look.

"Are you trying to kill me?" I linked him back. He just gave me an innocent smile, which I didn't buy for a moment. After breakfast I took Martin on a walk around the town to show him around. It didn't take long, as there really wasn't much to show. But it was nostalgic for me. Martin was sweet about it and listened to me rambling on about the place. We got a lot of attention, mostly from the single women in town. I found it hilarious watching them flirt with Martin, who categorically turned them down. It led to them giving me the stink eye, as if I was the reason he turned them down.

We headed back to eat lunch at the diner and then got ready for the wedding. I used the same dress I had worn on my bloodening. Martin dressed in a granite-grey suit.

"You look good," I told him.

“Thank you. You look beautiful as always,” he said. We drove out to the farm. CeCe and Jessie had hired the entire senior highschool class to act as sober drivers. It meant people didn’t need to skip the alcohol. The ceremony was beautiful. CeCe was dressed in a long, lace gown that moved in the wind. Jessie looked at her with so much love it had me in tears. Martin held out his handkerchief and I smiled as I took it.

“Thank you,” I mindlinked him.

“No problem. They make a beautiful couple and it’s easy to see how much they love each other,” he linked back.

“It is. I’m happy they finally took the leap.” He gave me a look I pretended not to see. We joined in with the other guests and cheered as CeCe and Jessie said ‘I do’ and then kissed. The party that followed was in true CeCe and Jessie spirit. The barn was decorated with lace fabric and hay bales. The tables were scattered throughout the open space and were decorated with wildflowers and fairy lights. Outside there was a fleet of BBQs set up, the diner had a table with side dishes and the local bar had an open bar for the guests. Martin and I made our way to the bride and groom. I hugged them both and Martin shook their hands.

“Congratulations! It was an amazing ceremony,” I told them.

“Thank you. I still can’t believe we actually did it,” CeCe giggled. “Is that the dress I forced you to buy? It looks amazing on you.”

“It is, and thank you.”

“Make sure you eat and drink and have a lot of fun,” Jessie told us.

“We will do our best,” Martin promised before we moved on to let others congratulate them. “You heard the man, time to have some fun,” Martin told me and wiggled his eyebrows. I laughed as we headed to get some food.

Both Martin and I had surprisingly much fun at the party. After we both had refused a couple of offers to dance, people got the picture and we spent most of the time chatting with people. Martin asked me to dance and he was a good dancer. Neither of us had been drinking and as evening turned to night and the party got a little wilder, we decided to head back to town. CeCe and Jessie had left at one point and we just waved to the sisters and some of the guests as we left.

“That was a nice wedding. I was afraid it would feel stiff as I didn’t know anyone but you,” Martin said as we were in the car.

“CeCe and Jamie are easy going. I’m not surprised they had an easy going wedding. It suited them,” I told him. We parked on the back of the coffeeshop. “Want to take a walk before we turn in?” I asked.

“Sure.” We walked along the lake and ended up on the same picnic table where Finlay and I had sat when we first met. The night was quiet, as most people in the town were at the wedding.

“What about you?” I asked.

“What about me, what?” Martin tried to evade.

“Are you looking for your true mate?” I asked, not letting him get away.

“Yeah. I can’t see myself settling down with anyone else, always wondering who is out there and if she is waiting for me. I’m not saying I don’t scratch the itch once in a while,” he told me and gave me a grin. “But it’s always with someone who knows it’s just for the night. We have a night of fun and everyone is happy.”

“Sounds like a good deal.”

“I’m not going to offer it to you,” he said.

“I hope not. I would hate to have to beat you up,” I told him. We looked at each other and laughed. We texted Sam and Finlay while we sat looking out over the lake. Then we headed back to sleep.

Chapter 21



Finlay

I was stretching out on the bed in my small room and was looking at the selfie Amy had sent me. It was of her and Martin sitting in the same place where I had got to know her the first time. They looked happy and relaxed. Amie was wearing her teal dress with the large flowers on it, and she looked even more beautiful than usual. I regretted that I couldn't be the one who accompanied her to her friends' wedding. But I needed to be here at the Alpha meeting. I was happy Martin had gone with her, I knew he would keep her safe. The two of them had grown close, in one way or the other they had both lost a sibling and they had found a surrogate in each other.

Red

Don't think you are fooling me with all the talk about how great the gathering is going. I know you can't talk freely with all the wandering ears around you. But know that when you get back home, we will talk about whatever is bothering you. I'll be waiting with a beer and if I'm in a good mood, I will have made a pie from those gigantic rhubarbs in your garden. Stay safe, Alpha.

I read Amie's message and smiled. It was nice to have someone who knew me well enough to see through my facade. It was irritating, but nice. The thing rubbing me the wrong way was my brother. Nothing new under the moon. It had been almost five years since I left his pack and he still hadn't let it go. What was worse, he had involved our mother and had taken her to this gathering as his plus one. My brother, I could ignore. Especially since I knew it drove him insane when I did it. My mother, that was another matter altogether. My mother had taken every opportunity she could to tell me how much she missed me. How the pack wasn't the same without me and all the others, and how my brother had grown and things were different. On one hand, I felt the guilt of hurting my mother. She had always been a good mother, and I loved her. On the other hand I felt hurt that she so clearly took my brother's side. She didn't take the time to talk to me, to see how happy I was. She didn't ask about the pack and every time I tried to tell her, she just changed the subject. As if it wasn't important. I sighed and put my arm over my eyes. I should really get some sleep. Two more days of this and then I could go home. I smiled as I imagined Amie making a pie in my kitchen. It wouldn't be the first time she cooked at my house. Ever since she had started tending to my garden, she insisted I needed to eat some of the produce. Most of it she collected and handed in to the kitchen. But sometimes I would get home and there would be a bowl with carrot and green pea soup waiting for me with instructions on how to reheat it. Or an upside down cake with whatever berries she had picked that day. The best times were when I got home while she was still in the middle of cooking. I would offer to help and she would refuse to let me. So I would sit at the kitchen table watching her cook, talking to her about our day. Evenings like those were everything I ever dreamed of. Maybe add a pup or two to the mix. It confused me how right it felt. Amie wasn't my mate, I knew it, my wolf knew it. In the past, when I had flirted with women, my wolf had always remained reserved. He allowed me to have some fun, but was always cold

towards it all. A silent reminder to not get attached. But with Amie, he had no reservation. He enjoyed the evenings in the kitchen as much as I did. He revelled in the late night runs in the forest with her wolf. All in all, it confused me and my wolf. I think it was just as confusing for Amie as well. Which is why we didn't talk about it. If we kept it undefined, we wouldn't need to deal with the possible fall out. It was a cowardly way of dealing with it. But too much was at stake. I still worried. If you buried your head in the sand, you only had a higher chance of getting shot in the ass. I felt myself gliding into sleep. Then there was a knock on the door and I sat up straight in the bed, scenting the air. I got up and put my pants on as I headed for the door. I pulled a t-shirt over my head as I opened the door.

"Councilman Rador, what do I owe the honour?" I asked and bowed my head ever so slightly. The elderly wolf outside my room returned the gesture.

"Alpha Finlay, I apologise for the late visit. May I come in and talk?" he asked. I stepped aside and showed him in. The room I have for the gathering was not much. But I had a queen size bed, a small desk pushed into a corner and a small round table with two chairs. I showed him to the table and he sat down.

"Can I offer you something to drink? I only have water and ice coffee," I offered.

"No thank you. I won't be long." I nodded and sat down in the other chair.

"Your brother has been talking to the council," Councilman Rador told me. I felt my mood souring.

"He has asked you to force a reconciliation?" I asked. The councilman looked at me with an appreciative look.

"You're smarter than you look, son. Yes, he has. The council has denied his request as we know the wolves who left with you did so of their own free will, and we don't want to take that freedom from them."

"But?" I asked. He wouldn't be here if they straight up had refused my brother.

"But. Are you sure this is the road you want to walk?" he asked me.

"I am. My pack is doing good. Better than good. We are thriving. Our land is vast and we have just purchased more. The pack members feel seen and heard, they create a stable pack. Everyone has their place in the pack and no one is more important than the others, not even me. It makes the pack feel safe to put down roots. Our settlement is growing and so is the pack. Two of our females are expecting pups. You know as well as I do the births of pups signals a stable pack. We are on good terms with the closest humans and there is harmony," I told him. It was all I had wanted to tell my mother. He nodded as he listened.

"But as an unranked pack, there are dangers," he pointed out. It was my turn to nod.

"We are aware of them. We hope the unknown acts as a deterrent, but we have taken precautions. We train everyone in the pack on what to do if the worst comes to worse."

"At least you have a plan. It means you and your top tier have at least thought about it. I won't try to persuade you to return to your brother's pack. I have quite liked to have you as an Alpha. You are doing a good job. The state of your pack is a testament of it. It will be interesting to see what you will do in the upcoming

games. Only five years left. Oh well, time for me to go. I'm too old to be up this late. Have a pleasant evening," the councilman said as he stood up.

"Thank you for coming to see me," I told him as I held open the door. He just nodded and left. This was a new low for my brother. I needed to think about what this could mean for the future, and why he was so determined to force us back into his pack.



Chapter 22



Amie

I looked out over the two new houses being built at the edge of the small town that were continuing to grow. I couldn't believe I had been here for over five years. One of the new houses was for a lone wolf we had recruited. Ramses had been with us for almost a year and he was fitting in as if he had always been with us. The other house was for one of the pack who had found her mate during one of the allied parties we had started to attend. The two had chosen to settle down in our pack. We were slowly growing. It was important to all of us that we didn't grow too fast. I turned around and headed back to the pack house for breakfast. The fall air was clear and the red and yellow leaves were slowly falling.

"How does it look?" Finlay asked as he came walking from the other direction and met me by the front door of the pack house.

"They are coming along great. It looks like they will be waterproof before the first storm hits," I told him as we walked inside.

"Perfect." We sat down at our usual table and Matilda joined us and started talking about the next hide and seek tournament. They were a beloved twice yearly tradition by now. Jake proved with each one that his skills were developing. There was the usual chatter in the dining hall. It all felt familiar by now. Suddenly, the room got dead quiet and everyone scented the air. I was the first one out of my chair and hurrying over to Medow, sweeping her up in a tight hug.

"Congratulations!" I shouted. The room burst out in activity as everyone wanted to congratulate the expecting parents. Finlay and Martin were congratulating Sam, who desperately tried to keep an eye on Medow. Medow was thanking everyone for their well wishes with a blush on her cheeks and a hand on her stomach. Sam finally managed to get away from his friends to get to Medow's side and place an arm around her.

"Don't fuss," she told him as he was about to object to the next batch of pack mates that wanted to congratulate the couple.

"Oh, just let him. It's part of the experience," Matilda said as she beamed a smile at the couple.

"Finally, someone sane," Sam said, sounding relieved. After reluctantly letting the rest of the pack congratulate them, Sam guided Medow to our table and had her sit down. She looked at me, rolled her eyes, and then giggled. I got the impression she didn't hate it nearly as much as she pretended to. Which was good as we would have seven months of Sam trying to protect her from any kind of danger. Well, more like six months. A pregnant wolf's scent didn't change until the third or fourth week of pregnancy, when the hormones really started to do their thing.

The conversation had started up around the room again when, for the second time, the room felt silent and everyone scented the air. It was Shelly and Jake who had walked into the dining room, closely followed by a beaming Cadence and Mari. Again, the room erupted into chaos as everyone wanted to congratulate the couple. Jake was as protective of his mate as Sam, even if it would be their third pup.

“Two pups at once,” I commented to Finlay when we sat down again.

“I know. It’s brilliant,” he said with a huge smile. I understood his happiness. Not only was he happy for his friends, it was also a sign the pack was thriving. Everyone knew fertility rates were closely connected to the stability of the pack when it came to werewolves. More pups were born in packs where the members were happy and felt safe, than in packs with unrest. It was such a clear sign of the pack’s health that Alphas would often boast about the number of pups born during a year in their packs. “Aunt, do you think you can arrange for a celebration for dinner?” he then asked Matilda.

“I would love to,” she said.

“Let me know if you need my help,” I said.

“Alpha, we would like for Medow’s parents, or at least her mother, to come here for the birth. Would that be okay?” Sam asked. Finlay smiled at him and Medow.

“The Cayote Hill pack is an ally and has always shown us kindness and friendship. I can’t see why your parents couldn’t come and visit us. Feel free to invite them,” Finlay said.

“Thank you, Alpha,” Medow said. When the conversation changed to another subject she turned to me.

“I was hoping you would be there when I give birth,” she told me.

“Me?” I asked, a little shocked.

“Yes. My mom will be there and so will Sam. My mom will have her hands busy with me, but I need someone to be there for Sam. We both know he will get all rallied up and he will try and protect me and the pup and I just want someone there who can calm him down,” she told me. I smiled at her. She knew her mate.

“I would be honoured to be there. And don’t worry about Sam. He will be amazing and if it’s needed, I will step in. I will even make sure to catch him if he faints,” I promised. Medow giggled and squeezed my hand.

“Thank you. I knew I could trust you.”

The day had started off good, and it continued in the same way. I helped Matilda make a huge cake for dessert and then joined the others as we had a top tier meeting to discuss a new business proposal Ramses had submitted. I had read through it and it looked promising. We were in the middle of debating it when two things happened at once. The first thing was the alarm in the pack house when off, alerting everyone our border had been breached. The second was a link from a patrolling warrior reporting a large amount of unknown, shifted wolves had entered into our land. We all stood as one.

“You need to stay here, lock yourself in the storage room with the others,” Sam told Medow.

"I will not!" she objected. Finlay, Martin and I were mindlinking different members of the pack, making sure people knew what to do.

"I will carry you there if I have to," Sam insisted.

"If you so much as touch me, I will use my claws on your privates and make sure this will be your only pup," Meadow growled. The fierce display from the usually sweet and mild tempered Meadow, had the room dead silent with all focus on her.

"Sure, baby. I won't do that," Sam told her.

"Good. Why are we all standing around?" she asked, and we all sprung into action again.

"Martin, take a team of warriors and head to the south. I will take a group to the west. Sam, set up a defence here in town. Meadow, make sure all those who can't fight are safe and report back to us if something is wrong. Amie, take the group with our best stealth warriors and gather as much info about these wolves as you can, preferably without being seen," Finlay gave out orders as we hurried through the pack house.

"Yes, Alpha!" we all said as one. Outside, we didn't take time to strip. We shifted as soon as our feet hit the ground. It was the first time I shifted through my clothes. It wasn't a pleasant experience. As my clothes ripped at the change, some parts remained, clinging to my body. I had to use my claws and teeth to get them off. Pack members too weak or sick to fight were heading towards the pack house. Meadow, who hadn't shifted, stood by the door giving out orders. Matilda joined her and together they organised the pack. The rest of us set off in different directions. I had just called the warriors I had been given responsibility over to

me, and was on my way to lay out the plan to them when Jake mindlinked the top tier.

"I need to head to the east hill," he told us.

"No. You are to man the operation room together with your group. You are responsible for the security system and the mechanical defences we have," Finlay linked back.

"I'm sorry, Alpha. Cadence just mind linked me. He and Jon were out collecting pine cones in that area and he has mindlinked me that they have hid in a small cave, but the area is full of unfamiliar wolves. I need to go and get them." This was bad, I realised. Jon's father and mother were both warriors, they couldn't abandon their post in the middle of an attack.

"I will go," I linked. "I have a higher chance of getting there undetected. I can scope out the situation and if possible guide the boys out. Worst case scenario I will protect them until help comes," I added. There was a short pause of silence.

"Do it," Finlay said.

"Thank you, Amie," Jack linked. I quickly told the warriors around me about the change of plans and gave them their mission. They sat off to gather information as I sat off towards the east hill. I thought I knew what cave Cadence and Jon had hid in. It was hard to find if you didn't know it was there. But it was small.

"Stay safe, if you need help, don't be too proud to ask for it," Finlay linked me in our private mindlink.

'I'm not a man, I will be careful. That goes for you as well. Don't let that Alpha pride be your downfall,' I answered.

'I will be careful.' I ran through the forest, trying to move as fast as I could while still being aware of my surroundings. I had a secret fear I would hesitate when I needed to act. I had never killed another werewolf. I had hunted deer and rabbits and other game which ran in the forest. But it was different with another werewolf. My answer came as I reached the top of a hill and saw another wolf standing at the foot on the other side. She was a stranger and my wolf did not hesitate. The strange wolf was a threat to me, and to my pack. I ran down the hill, the unknown wolf ran towards me as well. Halfway down the hill, I braced and leaped towards her. I took her by surprise and she didn't even try to swat at me with her claws as I sailed over her. As soon as I hit the ground, I turned around. The other wolf was trying to stop her forward movement. When she finally could turn around to come at me, I was ready. I swiped at her eyes with my claws, she turned her head away from me to avoid being hit, exposing her neck. I threw myself at her and closed my jaws around her throat. I felt her jugular tear and the warm fluid was everywhere. She tried to fight me off by clawing at my chest and face. She was losing strength quickly, and I only felt one or two wounds from her attempt. When I knew for certain she had no fight left in her and she would not survive. I let her go. I didn't have time to spare on celebrating my first victory. I turned around and kept running towards my goal. The closer I got to where I thought Cadence and Jon were, the more careful I was not to be spotted. The air was filled with the scent of strange wolves.

'Cade, Jon, are you okay?' I mindlinked the boys.

'Amie!' they both mindlinked back.

'We are okay, but there are a lot of wolves outside who we don't know,' Cadence told me.

'I know. I'm close. Are you in the small cave behind the pine tree?' I asked.

'Yes.'

'Good job. That is the best place to hide around here. Stay where you are and stay quiet.' I was now moving as slowly as possible to not let the other wolves know I was there. I was hoping to sneak close to the cave and keep watch as the boys sneaked out. Neither of them had their first shift yet, so they had to stay in their human form. It complicated things a bit, but I had hope. I slowly crawled to the top of the hill the cave was located in. I looked over the edge and any thought of getting the boys to sneak out of the cave was gone. Below was a large group of wolves, it seemed this was where they had set their base for the invasion. 'Finlay, the main force of the attackers are just below the cave by the pine tree where the boys are,' I mindlinked him.

'Fuck, okay, they need to stay in place and we will all work our way towards you. Stay put!' he replied.

'Amie?' Cadence's link was full of fear.

'I'm right above you, Cade. There are too many wolves out here for you to try and sneak out. Stay where you are.'

'A-are we going to be okay?' It broke my heart to hear how scared he was. I made the decision based on pure instinct.

‘I’m going down to them,’ I linked Finlay.

‘Damn it, Amie! Stay put! If you are seen it will be an issue,’ he told me.

‘If I’m seen, I will continue down the hill and turn north. The boys will be safe.’

‘But you won’t!’

‘They are scared, Finlay. If they panic they will give their location away, and I don’t stand a chance of saving them. I need to do this.’

‘Fine. But be careful and stay safe until we get there.’ I took a deep breath and wondered if I should shift into my human form. But decided against it. My human form was smaller, but it lacked advantages my wolf form had for traversing down the steep hill. I pressed myself as close to the ground as I could get and inched my way down the hillside. I made sure to use all the trees and bushes as cover and the gods smiled at me as the wind was blowing towards me. It made the scent of all the unknown wolves hit me, but my scent was blown away from them. Just as I was about to crawl into the cave, I caught the scent of a wolf I thought I recognised. I couldn’t place it and I tried to hone in on it. Then I snapped out of my thoughts and focused on the task. I managed to get into the small cave without being noticed. I was grateful the first snow hadn’t come. My red wolf stood out like a sore thumb against the white snow. But in a forest with fall colours, I blended in. Inside the cave, Cadence and Jon were huddled at the far wall. Their eyes were big and full of fear as they watched me enter the cave. As soon as they saw it was me I could see them relaxing. The cave was too small for me to stand in and it was cold. I did my best to manoeuvre myself inside, keeping quiet. I turned around so I was facing the entrance and backed up to let my body press into the boys. Even though they had on jackets, the coldness of the cave and them

sitting still for so long had them shivering. I shared my body heat and comforted them with my presence.

‘Are the two of you okay?’ I asked the boys in a mind link.

‘Yes,’ Cadence answered.

‘Better now that you are here,’ Jon linked.

‘The others are coming and will take care of the wolves outside. Until then, I will protect you. Stay close to each other and me to keep warm and stay quiet,’ I told them. The small cave would work to our advantage. Even if we were discovered, the wolves outside couldn’t rush in all at once. At the most they could come one at the time. I could defend our position against one wolf. ‘I’m with the boys. They are safe but cold and scared. No one saw me. We are staying put,’ I linked Finlay.

‘We are on our way,’ he told me. It felt like hours. I was focused on the scents and the sounds from outside. Ready to attack at any sign of an intruder. At the back of my mind, the familiar scent was gnawing at me. I knew I had scented the wolf before, but I couldn’t place it.

‘I can’t wait for the first snow,’ Cadence mindlinked me and Jon.

‘Same here,’ Jon replied.

‘Yeah? What is the best thing about the snow?’ I asked to keep them going and keep them occupied with happier thoughts.

‘When you take us out into the woods. It’s always fun and you always pack hot cocoa and treats,’ Jon said without hesitation. I smiled internally at the answer. It was nice to know they liked our outings and picnics. The thought of having picnics with the pups triggered the memory I associated with the scent. A picnic table covered in snow and an offer of coffee and sandwiches. I reached out to Finlay, Martin and Sam.

‘It’s the Rolling Hills pack,’ I linked them.

‘That is attacking?’ Sam asked.

‘Yes. I scented their Gamma. It took me a moment to place the scent, but I’m sure it’s him,’ I told them. We hadn’t heard anything from the pack since our meeting with them. Finlay told us that even at the joint pack gatherings, they stayed clear of him.

‘They must have become desperate,’ Finlay linked. ‘Now we know it’s not a loosely put together group of loner wolves. Make sure everyone knows it’s a pack that is attacking and adjust the tactics.’

‘Yes, Alpha,’ we all answered.

‘How are you holding up?’ Finlay linked me in our private link.

‘We are doing good.’

‘It’s taking us longer to reach you than I thought, but if we are fighting a pack it makes sense. They have trained together and are working as one. Just hold on and don’t do anything stupid,’ he told me.

‘I won’t. And the same goes for you.’ I continued my wait. I could sense Cadence and Jon mindlinking each other. It was good they kept their mind off the situation and I appreciated them leaving me out of their conversation so I could focus on listening and scenting. There were still a large amount of wolves outside. But they seemed to keep to the forest floor below the hill, most likely thinking they were alone and the steep hill would keep them hidden. Then something changed. The first growl I heard I took for someone being impatient. They had clearly been given orders to wait while their pack mates were out fighting. The second growl I heard was not one of impatience, it was aggressive.

‘Are you close? Something is happening outside, someone is getting pissy,’ I mindlinked Finlay, Martin and Sam.

‘We are at least ten minutes away,’ Finlay was the first to answer.

‘It’s about the same for us,’ Sam linked.

‘We are closer, but not close enough to make them react,’ Martin told us. There was a new set of growls from outside the cave. This time it wasn’t an individual, I could clearly hear three distinct growls. The sound of fighting followed.

‘They are fighting,’ I reported.

‘With who? I don’t have any reports of our warriors being in the area,’ Sam asked.

‘I think they are fighting amongst themselves. There are no familiar scents I can identify.’ Some of the growling outside was turning into yelps and whines. Someone was losing. My blood froze as I heard the loser starting to claw themselves up the steep incline. They were trying to get away from their pack

mates and heading straight for us. 'They are coming towards us,' I informed the others and stood up as best as I could in the small space. 'You two, huddle as close to the back wall as possible. I will block anyone trying to come in. The pack is on its way,' I told Cadence and Jon. Their eyes were huge, but they nodded.

'Amie,' Finlay linked.

'It will be fine. We are fine. Don't take stupid risks. We can hold them off,' I told him.

'I'm giving you a direct order not to die. I will be truly pissed as your Alpha if you disobey.'

'Understood.'

'We are coming, Amie,' Martin mind linked me.

'Be careful. There are a lot of them outside. I can keep the cave safe for a while if they discover it. Don't do anything foolish,' I told him. I heard the wolf outside get closer. My wolf and I both focused on the sound. I could tell the moment the wolf saw the opening, they stopped moving and I could hear them scenting the air. There was no way they could avoid catching my scent now that they focused on the opening. A growl was heard and it was accompanied by others. Oh great, they have made up in order to kill us, I thought. The moment I saw a black paw in the opening of the cave, I lunged at it and sank my claws into it before drawing back just as quickly. The paw disappeared back out and a new set of growls was heard. Next a grey wolf tried to rush into the cave. They hadn't taken the size of the cave into account and their forward movement halted as they lowered themselves to the ground. I again jumped forward, and this time I swiped at their eyes with my

claws. They turned their heads at the last second, but couldn't turn all the way because of the narrow opening. My claws ripped deep gouges into their cheek and I shredded their left ear. They roared and tried to swipe out their claws at me. I jumped back and due to their awkward position, they couldn't pursue me. I jumped forward again. This time I aimed my claws at their throat and shoulder. The grey wolf turned around and snapped its teeth at my paw. I withdrew it to avoid the razor-sharp teeth, but in doing so, I left my left shoulder exposed. I could feel the claws digging into it and I roared. I took a page out of the attacker's book and bent down and sank my teeth into its paw. It was their turn to roar in pain, and I clamped down my jaw and refused to let go. They struggled against my bite, but they were only halfway inside the cave and the small opening restricted their movements. I could hear their pack mates outside, trying to push past them to help. But there wasn't enough space. I heard the bones in the paw snapping and I felt it beneath my teeth. I wanted to spit it out, it felt gross as the warm blood seeped into my mouth. But I steeled myself. As long as I had their paw, they were stuck, and the boys were safe. I growled and put more pressure on my jaws. The grey wolf whimpered and in a desperate attempt to get free, they put weight on the paw in my mouth. The unexpected extra weight made me lean my bad shoulder against the cave wall. I growled and as I did, my opponent yanked on their paw and with a loud yelp they freed it. But it was badly mangled. Pieces of flesh and skin had been ripped from it and I spit them out. The grey wolf retreated slowly from the cave, its mangled paw held as high above the ground as it could manage. I growled as loudly as I could and inflated myself to look as big as possible. My red wolf took up almost the entirety of the cave. My growl got a response this time. A familiar growl came as a reply and it was followed by a group of others. Martin and the group of warriors he had taken had arrived. I heard the commotion when the two groups collided. A whimper escaped from the boys behind me. I put my tail over them, it was the only comfort I could provide.

There was still at least one wolf outside the opening to the cave. Probably to keep me from attacking the back of the group fighting Martin. I wouldn't have joined the fight even if I could have. My duty was to keep the boys safe. If the wolf outside the cave hadn't been there, I would have tried to sneak them out while the others were distracted. But now I had to wait. The wounds in my shoulder made me less agile, and I wasn't confident I would win in a fight against the wolf guarding us. I knew I couldn't afford to lose, so I had to wait and listen to the sounds of the battle. The air was filled with the scent of blood and death. I couldn't tell from the sound and scent who was winning. I didn't want to mindlink the ones fighting, afraid I would distract them. My ears strained to pick up sounds from the wolves that were a part of my pack. I heard a sound I wished I hadn't. Martin growled and his growl slowly faded, I could hear him struggling to keep it going, as if he refused to give in. My wolf growled and as Martin's growl started to fade into nothing, my growl turned into a whimper.

'He will need you. Stay safe, little sister,' Martin mindlinked me. When I tried to reply, to tell him to hang in there. I was met by emptiness, there was nothing to connect to even though I desperately tried. I needed to connect to him. I needed him to be okay. The alternative was unthinkable. My wolf's whine turned into a howl. That is when it hit us all. The raw pain radiating from our Alpha. Finlay's sorrow and pain felt like a physical punch and I was almost on my way to charge the offending wolf outside the cave. I needed an outlet for the pain and the grief.

"Amie," Cadence said, his voice weak, full of fear and pain. It stopped my attack. I backed further into the cave to press myself against the two boys.

'It will be okay,' I mindlinked them, even if I knew it wouldn't.

'What's wrong with the Alpha? Is he hurt?' Jon linked back. I realised they hadn't understood the meaning of Martin's growl, they didn't know.

'He will be okay. It's not something that will stop him,' I said. As I said it the wave of immense pain from Finlay stopped. He had closed himself off to stop the pain from affecting the pack. He put it on his own shoulders and isolated himself for the good of the pack. For now. He will need you. Martin's words rang in my head. My human part desperately wanted to cry, my wolf part wanted to leave the cave and rip every single wolf outside to pieces. Neither of us did what we wanted. Instead, I pressed my body against the boys and my wolf growled continuously in a long, deep growl from the belly. We both hoped one of the enemy wolves would dare to set a paw inside the cave. We craved the outlet of anger and revenge. As I listened, I could hear how more of our pack arrived, the intruders were soon outnumbered.

'You can come out. The boy's mothers are waiting on the top of the hill,' Sam mindlinked me.

'We can get out of here now. I want the two of you to grab hold of my tail really well. When we get out of the cave, I want you to look up towards the top of the hill. Do not look down. Do you understand?' I linked the boys.

"Yes Amie," they both said as one.

'You have both been really good and done a good job. Your parents will be so proud of you,' I told them as we moved forward. It was a little awkward getting out of the cave. The boys had been inside it for a long time and their muscles were cold and stiff. Outside, I used my claws to make sure both I and the boys could scale the steep incline. I tried to make sure there were trees and bushes blocking

the view below us, in case they got curious and wanted a look. Pain shot from my shoulder, but I blocked it from my mind. There was a bigger pain in my chest and I focused on getting us safe to the top of the hill. When we got up there, the boys' mothers engulfed their sons in tight hugs and looked them over.

"Thank you Amie," Shelly told me. I nodded at them and turned around to head down to where the fight had taken place. When I cleared the bushes and could see the forest floor below me, I could see the massacre. There were dead wolves everywhere. I tried to take stock and concluded I didn't recognise most of them. I saw Martin's brown wolf laying a little up the hill. I steered my steps towards him. My wolf nudged him with its nose, waiting to see if its friend would stand again. When the nudge didn't get a response, both me and my wolf sighed. I looked up and saw where Finlay and Sam stood, both had their focus on a badly injured wolf. I scented the air as I walked closer. Alpha Jackson. A growl escaped me. Both Finlay and Sam turned their heads to look at me. I could see the pain and anger in them both. Finlay looked down at my shoulder.

'You are hurt,' he linked. I shrugged, which was a bad move as the pain got worse and made me flinch.

'It's nothing,' I told him. "What do we do now?" I asked.



Amie

'Now we make sure the wounded are looked after and the wolves we have captured need to be kept safe. We have questions for this one,' Finlay linked us. An agreeing growl came from both Sam and me. While Finlay and I stayed to keep watch of the enemy Alpha, Sam walked around and organised the warriors. He made sure those who were injured but could walk, headed for the pack house. He had men coming to collect the injured and the dead. And then he had some warriors guarding the captured enemies. When we were all set, we indicated to the captured Alpha to get moving. All three of us stayed close to him and made sure he headed in the direction we wanted. He was clearly injured and was limping on two legs and left a trail of blood behind him. No one cared. Anyone we met growled at him and it soothed my soul to know we reacted as a pack. Back at the pack house, we had cells that could withstand a werewolf's strength. They were rarely used, but on occasion someone had too much to drink and needed a safe space to sober up in. Alpha Jackson was placed in one of the cells and the remainder of his pack was put into the newly built school gym, guarded by warriors.

'Go and shift back, take a shower and we will meet back here in thirty minutes,' Finlay told us. We headed off in different directions. I changed back outside my door and walked inside to take a quick shower and put on some clothes. I looked at my shoulder in the mirror. The wounds from the claws were healing, but they were deep, and it would take a couple of days for them to be gone. At least they weren't bleeding. I just let them be and pulled a sweater on and walked back to the cells. Finlay was already there in his human form. He had an expression on his face I hadn't seen before, it was a mix of hate, anger and sadness and it almost broke my heart. I knew now wasn't the time, so I just stood next to him and looked at the prisoner, still in wolf form. Sam and Medow walked in next. Sam had his arm around his mate and Medow looked devastated. She looked at me with red rimmed eyes and I stepped up to her and gave her a hug.

"Are you sure you want to be here?" I asked her. She looked at Sam and snuggled in closer to him and gave me a nod. I understood, she needed to be close to her mate.

"Shift," Finlay told Alpha Jackson. We all turned our focus to the wolf inside the cell. Nothing happened.

"Too weak?" I asked and let my voice remain light and mocking. I knew how his pack viewed women and me suggesting he was weak would be more effective than any attempts of ordering him to change. He growled at me. Which made Finlay growl at him. Finlay's growl was more powerful than the imprisoned Alpha's. With a glare at me, Alpha Jackson shifted to his human form. In his naked state it was easy to see the injuries he had. But more than that, the Alpha seemed to be in a worse condition than when I had seen him last time. It had been years since then. But he was an Alpha in the prime of his life. He should not look

thin. He tried to hold himself up in a confident pose, but it was easy to see he was hurting.

“Speak! Why have you done this?” Finlay asked him as he tossed a pair of shorts at him. The Alpha smirked and did his best to keep up his arrogant behaviour. He waved the shorts in his hand.

“Afraid your women will see how a real Alpha looks?” he asked. I snorted.

“Please, I have seen bigger on pups. Let’s hope you’re a grower, or this is really embarrassing for you,” I said. Behind me, Meadow giggled and Sam laughed. Even Finlay pulled one corner of his mouth up in a half smirk. Alpha Jackson growled, but was ignored by everyone. He put the shorts on and had to lean against the wall to do so.

“Now. Why the fuck did you attack us?” Finlay asked again.

“You refused to merge with us,” Alpha Jackson told him.

“That was four years ago,” I objected. The Alpha shrugged.

“The pack didn’t want to attack you. Me and my Beta were for it from the start but my Gamma and the pack in general were against it. They felt it was too big of a risk. You seemed to be strong according to them. I tried to tell them no pack is strong when it has just split from another pack. And a pack that lets a female into its top tier without being a mate to the high ups, they are weak,” he said.

“I guess you should have listened to your Gamma and your pack,” Sam told him.

“If we had just attacked four years ago, we would have won. We waited too long. They are all a bunch of cowards. In the end, I had to use my Alpha status to make them. I told them that anyone refusing to take part in the attack would be named a traitor and made rogue. Much help that did. The fuckers were too weak. My own Gamma turned against me when we got here. When our pack members started dying, he wanted to withdraw. Fucking coward. He didn’t understand that I sent those pack members in first, as I knew they were weak. They were to tire you out, to pave the road for our victory. But he didn’t like that. Didn’t think it was the honourable thing to do. Well, it didn’t end well for him.” The fighting I had heard outside the cave.

“I will inform the council of what has happened,” Finlay told him.

“Are you not Alpha enough to finish me off without their consent?” Alpha Jackson mocked him.

“I will not take revenge on you on a whim, because I can’t control my emotions. We both know what sanctions the council can put on a pack for something like that. My pack will not suffer just because I feel like ending your pathetic life. Not when I have enough evidence to secure they grant me full right to do so. I will see you again once their decision is made,” Finlay said. We all knew that was the end of the conversation and we all headed for the main floor. “I will call the council, they need to know what has happened. Amie, check on the pack, make sure they feel that we have things under control. Talk to my aunt. I’m sure she is already working on it. Sam, you need to make a schedule for the warriors. If rumour spread about the attack, others might strike against us, thinking we are weak,” Finlay gave out orders.

“Yes, Alpha,” we all said. Sam and Medow headed to his office.

“Do you want me to call Martin’s mother?” I asked Finlay. He had stopped outside his office in the pack house and for a moment he dropped his mask and I could see how tired he looked. He rubbed his hand over his face.

“No, I will call her,” he said after hesitating.

“You have a lot on your plate, I can do it,” I insisted. He looked at me and then he turned his eyes to my shoulder.

“Have you been seen by a healer?” he asked.

“It’s not that bad. It will heal,” I told him.

“Don’t be so stubborn. Go and have yourself checked out, then make sure the pack is alright. I will make the call to the council and then I will call Martin’s mother.”

“Fine. Let me know if you need me for something. I will be around,” I said.

“Thank you.” We stood there for a moment before I saw him slip his mask on and head for his office. I headed for the room where the healers had set up. There weren’t many people in there, as most who needed help had already received it. They took a look at my shoulder. I got a stern talking to for not coming sooner. They put on some ointment and told me to come back if I got a fever or if the area around the wounds got hot. I headed out and spent the rest of the day just walking around, talking to the pack. Most of them were relieved the attack had been over so quickly, but everyone mourned the loss of our Beta. There was a lot of anger,

but I tried to steer the feelings towards community and helping each other. Besides Martin, we had lost two warriors and five more were severely wounded. We needed to make sure to take care of them and their families. Matilda was right there and worked with me. I had asked her to organise the funerals. Medow was making sure the injured wolves had what they needed as well as their families. Overall we were in a better condition than I would have thought.

‘The council has decided the Alpha of the Rolling Hills pack has forfeited his life. The execution will be done tomorrow by my hand,’ Finlay sent a mindlink to the pack later in the evening. ‘The rest of the captives are ours to do with as we please. We will make the decision tomorrow as well,’ he continued. The news affected the pack positively. Everyone felt they had been given the chance to seek the revenge we all wanted. By the time I was ready to end the day, it was close to midnight. Instead of going to my apartment, I headed for Finlay’s house. I didn’t bother to knock, but walked inside and into the living room. Finlay was sitting on the couch in the dark room. His elbows on his knees and his head resting in his hands. I walked up to the fireplace. I knew he always kept it stocked this time of year. It lit without an issue. I walked over to the couch and sat down next to him.

“I don’t know if I can do this,” he said without looking up.

“I know how you feel, but you will find a way,” I told him.

“Did you get your shoulder checked out?”

“I did. They told me I was wasting their time,” I said. Finlay turned his head and gave me a sideways look. “Fine. They scolded me for not coming sooner and gave me an ointment. But that’s just because all healers think it’s the end of the world if you don’t come and see them when you stub your toe.”

"I can't deal with losing you as well." His voice was frail and thin. It was like the thought itself hurt him. I sighed and bent forward so I could lean my forehead on his slumped shoulder blade.

"You won't. It really isn't that bad. It hurts like hell but it's healing and at the most I will have a scar on my shoulder. But I'm not going anywhere," I promised him.

"Good." We sat like that for a while in silence. "How are the boys doing?" he asked.

"Good. I talked to them after dinner and they have got over the worst of it. Give them a week or two and they will see it as scary, but exciting. I think we kept them away from seeing the worst of it. They were more than happy with all the hot coco and attention they got after."

"You," he said.

"Sorry?"

"You kept them away from the worst of it, not we. And you kept them safe when you were discovered."

"And I failed to get them out of there. I decided we needed to stay put and by doing so I forced the rest of you to come and rescue us. It's my fault we lost him," I told Finlay.

"Amie," he objected and sat up for the first time. I took a deep breath and shook my head as the tears started rolling down my face. I had been keeping them at bay

until now. But right now it was just Finlay and I knew I could be weak around him.

"I made the decision that ended with us losing Martin, our Beta. That is on me," I insisted.

"It's not your fault. You made the only reasonable decision you could make. If you had tried to get the boys out you would have been detected and we would have lost the three of you," Finlay told me. He gently put his arm around me and drew me closer to him. I rested my head on his shoulder and he rested his on top of mine. "His mother was devastated. She cried and asked if I would send his ashes back to them."

"He wouldn't have wanted that," I said.

"No, he wouldn't. I told her we would scatter his ashes over our pack land. The land he gave his life to protect and which he loved."

"It was the right thing to do," I assured him.

"I know. But it felt horrible." I put my arms around his waist and we sat like that. We shared our sorrow and let each other have time to think. When dawn's first light was visible outside, Finlay sighed. "We will need a new Beta," he said. My first instinct was to object. The position belonged to Martin. But he wasn't with us any longer. I nodded as best I could in my position.

"Do you have any candidates?" I asked.

"One."